08. Sky Islands

Nova Cup · upgrade blueprint · src/kart/tracks/sky.ts

Where it is now

3.2 km: island leaps, glass highway, glass bridge or airship deck, glide off the summit. Lap 2 crosswind; last lap gale.

What is wrong

Islands are just road pieces with gaps; the glides are rides, not skills.

Core mechanic

Wind and floating ground. Islands drift slowly, so the gaps between them change each lap. Updrafts let you gain height while gliding, so gliding becomes a skill: chain updrafts to reach high short cuts.

Signature moments

- A glide chain: hop from updraft to updraft to reach a high island short cut.
- The airship: its deck moves while you drive on it.
- Drifting islands: arrive when the gap is short or wait for it.

Layout changes

- Make three islands drift on slow loops.
- Add an updraft route as a fork.
- Keep the glass highway as the calm section.

Lap changes

- Lap 2: crosswind on the bridges.
- Last lap: a gale pushes the islands apart; only the updraft route connects.

Engine work needed

- Moving road pieces (drifting islands, the airship).
- Updraft force zones that lift gliders.
- Gaps that change size during a race.

Rivals

- Rivals judge gap size and use updrafts.

Done when

- Laps of 50-60 s for a good driver; all 3-lap test races finish with no errors.
- Rivals use every route and the core mechanic, with no more than 2 rival falls per race.
- The core mechanic is in play for at least half the lap, not just one set piece.
- A blind test: a screenshot or a 10-second clip of this track could not be mistaken for any other track.
- Item rows are never on the start line; nothing solid blocks a road by accident.